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For Victor Carpay, Communications Gregory the Great Institute Last updated: August 2026

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1. How the System Works

Every person in ActiveCampaign has three layers of data you can filter on:

Layer	What it is	Example
Lists	Which email streams they opted into	Newsletter, Events, Partners in Renewal
Tags	Labels describing how they found us, what they're interested in, and what role they play	`source:zeffy`, `interest:book-study`, `role:ambassador`
Custom Fields	Structured data attached to each contact	Donor Tier = "Patron", Lifetime Giving = $2,400

Lists control *who can receive email* (consent). **Tags** and **Fields** control *who should receive which email* (targeting).

A **Segment** is a saved filter that combines these layers. You don't create a new list for every campaign — you build a segment.

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2. Your Three Email Lists

List	Who's on it	Use it for
Newsletter (Magnalia Letter)	Everyone who signed up via the website, contact form, or reading guide download. Your broadest audience.	Monthly Magnalia letter, general announcements, soft fundraising CTAs
Institute Events	People who registered for events or signed up for book studies.	Event invitations, program announcements, post-event follow-ups
Partners in Renewal	Anyone who has ever made a donation through Zeffy. Added automatically by the webhook.	Fundraising appeals, impact reports, stewardship updates, tax receipt reminders

Key rule: A person can be on multiple lists. A monthly donor who also subscribes to the newsletter is on both *Newsletter* and *Partners in Renewal*. When you build a segment, you choose which list(s) to draw from.

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3. Understanding Tags

Tags use a `category:value` naming convention. Here are the categories:

Source Tags — *How did they find us?*

Tag	Meaning
`source:website`	Signed up through a website form
`source:zeffy`	Came in through a Zeffy donation
`source:event`	Registered at a live event
`source:reading-guide`	Downloaded the reading guide

Donor Tags — *What kind of giver are they?*

Tag	Meaning
`donor:monthly`	Active recurring donor
`donor:one-time`	Made a one-time gift
`donor:prospect`	Engaged but hasn't donated yet

Tag	Meaning
`donor:lapsed`	Previously gave, but no gift in 12+ months
`donor:honor-memorial`	Made an honour/memorial gift

Interest Tags — *What are they interested in?*

Tag	Meaning
`interest:book-study`	Signed up for or asked about book studies
`interest:events`	General event interest
`interest:masterclass`	Interested in masterclass series
`interest:magnalia-journal`	Interested in the print journal
`interest:speaker-booking`	Inquired about booking a speaker
`interest:volunteering`	Expressed interest in volunteering
`interest:programs`	General programs interest
`interest:courses`	Interest in courses
`interest:think-tank`	Interest in think-tank programming

Role Tags — *What role do they play?*

Tag	Meaning
`role:ambassador`	Confirmed ambassador
`role:ambassador-applicant`	Applied, not yet confirmed
`role:career-applicant`	Submitted a job application
`role:book-study-leader`	Hosts a book study group
`role:leadership-inquiry`	Expressed interest in major giving
`role:prayer-partner`	Prayer partner

Campaign Tags — *Event/campaign specific (created as needed)*

Tag	Meaning
`campaign:conference-2026`	2026 conference registrant
`campaign:music-camp-2026`	2026 music camp registrant
`campaign:general-donation`	General (non-campaign) donation

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4. Understanding Custom Fields

These are the structured data fields on each contact. The ones most useful for fundraising:

Field	What it contains	Example
Donor Tier	Calculated tier based on trailing 12-month giving	“Patron”
Trailing 12mo Giving	Dollar amount given in the last 12 months	$750.00
Lifetime Giving	Total amount given all-time	$2,400.00
Largest Single Gift	Their biggest one-time donation	$500.00
First Gift Date	When they first donated	2024-03-15
Last Gift Date	Their most recent donation	2026-07-01
Donation Count	Number of individual transactions	12
City	Contact’s city	Calgary
Province	Contact’s province	AB
Consent Status	Express / Implied / None	Express

These fields are updated automatically every time a donation comes through Zeffy. You don’t need to maintain them manually.

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5. Donor Tiers Explained

Tiers are calculated from the **trailing 12-month giving total** (not lifetime). They update automatically with each donation.

Tier	Annual Giving	Typical Profile
General Donor	Under $180/yr	Small or first-time givers
Friend	$180 – $599/yr	Regular supporters (~$15+/mo)
Patron	$600 – $4,999/yr	Committed supporters (~$50+/mo)
Leadership Partner	$5,000 – $24,999/yr	Major donors
Visionary Partner	$25,000+/yr	Transformational partners

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6. Building Segments

In ActiveCampaign, go to **Contacts → Segments** (or build inline when creating a campaign).

How Segment Conditions Work

You combine conditions with **AND** (all must be true) or **OR** (any can be true):

- **AND** narrows your audience: "On Partners list AND Donor Tier is Patron"
- **OR** broadens it: "Donor Tier is Patron OR Donor Tier is Leadership Partner"

Step-by-Step: Create a Segment

1. Go to **Contacts** in the left sidebar
2. Click **"Advanced Search"** (or the filter icon)
3. Add your first condition (e.g., *Tag exists: donor:monthly*)
4. Click **"+ Add another condition"** for additional filters
5. Choose AND/OR between conditions
6. Once your results look right, click **"Save as Segment"**
7. Give it a clear name (e.g., "Monthly Donors — Active")

You can now select this segment when sending campaigns.

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7. Fundraising Playbook — Ready-Made Segments

Here are the segments you'll use most often, with exact conditions to build them:

Year-End Appeal — Broad

Purpose: Annual fundraising ask to everyone who has given or shown interest.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	List	is	Partners in Renewal
	OR		
2	Tag	exists	donor:prospect

Who gets it: All past donors + engaged non-donors flagged as prospects.

Year-End Appeal — Major Donor Version

Purpose: Personalized, higher-touch version of the appeal for your best supporters.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	List	is	Partners in Renewal
	AND		
2	Donor Tier	is	Leadership Partner
	OR		
3	Donor Tier	is	Visionary Partner

Who gets it: $5,000+/yr donors. These people should get a different letter — more personal, more vision-casting, possibly hand-signed.

Lapsed Donors — Re-engagement

Purpose: Win back people who used to give but stopped.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Tag	exists	donor:lapsed
	AND		
2	Lifetime Giving	is greater than	0

Who gets it: Anyone tagged as lapsed (no gift in 12+ months) who has given before. Tone: “We miss your partnership” — not guilt, gratitude.

Monthly Donors — Stewardship

Purpose: Thank and retain your most reliable supporters.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Tag	exists	donor:monthly

Who gets it: All active recurring donors. Use for: impact updates, exclusive behind-the-scenes content, upgrade asks (e.g., “Could you add $10/month?”).

Upgrade Candidates — Friend → Patron

Purpose: Identify loyal mid-level supporters who might increase their giving.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Donor Tier	is	Friend
	AND		
2	Donation Count	is greater than	3

Who gets it: Friends who’ve given 4+ times — they’re committed. A gentle ask to increase could move them to Patron level.

Engaged Non-Donors

Purpose: People who are clearly interested but haven’t donated yet.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	List	is	Newsletter
	AND		
2	Tag	does not exist	donor:one-time

#	Condition	Operator	Value
	AND		
3	Tag	does not exist	donor:monthly
	AND		
4	Has opened/clicked	in the last	90 days

Who gets it: Newsletter subscribers who read your emails but have never given. These are warm leads. Soft ask with a compelling story.

Event Attendees — Post-Event Follow-Up

Purpose: Thank people who attended a specific event and invite them deeper.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Tag	exists	campaign:conference-2026

Who gets it: Everyone tagged for that specific event. Use for: thank-you emails, survey links, next event invitations, first-time donor asks.

Local Supporters (by Province or City)

Purpose: Geographic targeting for regional events or in-person cultivation.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Province	is	AB
	AND		
2	List	is	Partners in Renewal

Who gets it: Alberta-based donors. Useful for: in-person dinner invitations, regional event promotion, local volunteer recruitment.

VIP / High-Touch List

Purpose: Your most important relationships — board members, major donors, key influencers.

#	Condition	Operator	Value
1	Tag	exists	flag:vip

Who gets it: Anyone you've manually tagged as VIP. Use sparingly — these are people who should hear from Ryan or the board chair directly, not from a mass email.

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8. Sending a Campaign to a Segment

1. Go to **Campaigns → Create a Campaign**
2. Choose your campaign type (Standard is most common)
3. On the **"List"** step, select the relevant list (e.g., Partners in Renewal)
4. On the **"Segment"** step, choose your saved segment — or build conditions inline
5. Review the contact count — AC shows you exactly how many people match
6. Design your email, preview, and send

Always preview the contact count. If it looks way too high or too low, double-check your conditions before sending.

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9. Tips & Guardrails

Do

- **Save segments with clear names.** Future you will thank present you. Use format: `[Purpose] — [Audience]` (e.g., "Year-End Appeal — Major Donors")
- **Check contact count before sending.** If your "major donors" segment has 800 people, something is wrong.
- **Use the preview/test send feature.** Send yourself a test before blasting the full list.
- **Combine list + segment.** Always start with a list (consent boundary), then narrow with tags/fields.
- **Let the system handle tiers.** Don't manually set Donor Tier — the Zeffy webhook updates it automatically.

Don't

- **Don't create new lists for every campaign.** Use tags and segments instead. Lists are consent boundaries, not targeting tools.
- **Don't email people on no list.** If someone isn't on Newsletter, Events, or Partners in Renewal, they haven't opted in to that stream. Use tags to add them to the right list first.
- **Don't manually tag donors.** The webhook handles `donor:monthly`, `donor:one-time`, tier calculations, and giving totals. Manual tags will get overwritten.
- **Don't delete contacts to "clean up."** If someone hasn't engaged, let the lapse detection handle it. Deleted contacts lose all history.
- **Don't send fundraising appeals to Newsletter-only subscribers.** They signed up for content, not asks. Use soft CTAs in the newsletter; save direct appeals for the Partners in Renewal list.

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10. Quick Reference — Tag & Field Cheat Sheet

Tags You'll Use Most for Fundraising

What you want	Tag to filter on
All recurring donors	`donor:monthly`
One-time donors	`donor:one-time`
Stopped giving	`donor:lapsed`
Interested but never gave	`donor:prospect`
Honour/memorial gifts	`donor:honor-memorial`
Leadership-level interest	`role:leadership-inquiry`
VIPs	`flag:vip`

Fields You'll Use Most for Fundraising

What you want to filter	Field name	Example condition
High-value donors	Donor Tier	is "Leadership Partner"
Recent donors	Last Gift Date	is after [date]
Lapsing donors	Last Gift Date	is before [12 months ago]

What you want to filter	Field name	Example condition
Donors who could upgrade	Trailing 12mo Giving	is between $180 and $599
Long-time supporters	First Gift Date	is before [2 years ago]
Donors in a specific city	City	is “Calgary”
High capacity	Largest Single Gift	is greater than $1,000

Questions? Ask Evan or email evanropp@gmail.com.